ODISHA

THE WINNING HABIT

By Romita Datta

A strange sort of veneration confronts you when you mention Naveen Patnaik in Odisha. Biju Janata Dal MP Amar Patnaik gets a little emotional when he says, "He is like family: a grandfather to children, father to many, brother to women."

It perhaps explains the 75-year-old BJD patriarch's uninterrupted run in the state for the past 22 years. Be it parliamentary elections or for assembly, municipal or even rural bodies, his party sweeps them all with mandates so comprehensive that other parties seem like extras in some Naveen Patnaik show.

So it was with the latest panchayat elections (held from February 16-24), where the BJD won 766 of the 851 zilla parishad zones, while the BJP and Congress managed inconsequential tallies of 42 and 37 seats, respectively. While the Congress did retain 60 per cent of the seats it won last time, the BJP saw a massive erosion of its base in the Mayurbhanj, Malkangiri and Kalahandi areas, with its tally plunging from the 297 seats won in the 2017 panchayat poll.

Naveen has indeed rendered anti-incumbency an alien word in Odisha's politics. From the time Biju Patnaik's youngest child took over the reins of the state after his father's death in 1997, forming the Biju Janata Dal soon after and becoming the chief minister in 2000, extensive social welfare has been integral to state politics. Amar Patnaik lauds him for standing strong and tall, "someone who can be trusted to stand with people in bad weather". That reference is more than just metaphorical. Naveen has helped his people weather some 20 storms and cyclones in his 22-year stint, to implement a 'Zero Casualty Mission'.



ANI

STANDING TALL
On his father Biju Patnaik's 106th birth anniversary, Mar. 5

His commitment remains unwavering as he serves out a fifth term. Thanking the people after his party's landslide win in the panchayat polls, Naveen said it strengthened his resolve to do public service. The CM's social welfare schemes have only enhanced his popularity. Not only has he rolled out fresh schemes but also redesigned existing ones to expand their reach. The Biju Swasthya Kalyan Yojana, for instance, now serves 70 per cent of the state's population. Initially providing health insurance of up to Rs 5 lakh annually to a family of five, it now includes an additional annual assistance of Rs 5 lakh for women members of each such family. "Every day, one lakh people, covered under this scheme, are getting treatment in government hospitals while another 30,000 are being treated in private hospitals, which include big names like Apollo, CMC Vellore and Tata Memorial," says chief secretary Suresh Mahapatra. "The government is spending Rs 40 crore a month and we are looking to increase it to Rs 600-1,000 crore a year."

THE BJD WON AN INCREDIBLE 766 OF THE 851 ZILLA PARISHAD ZONES IN THIS YEAR'S PANCHAYAT POLLS

Mahapatra also believes that the state government's management of the Covid pandemic tilted the scale in the BJD's favour. The government claims to have provided free medical treatment to over 100,000 Covid patients, irrespective of any cap on income. "About 4,000-15,000 people got admitted for treatment on a daily basis, depending on the intensity of Covid," says Mahapatra. "The government spent Rs 2,000 crore." Throughout the pandemic, Odisha also doggedly pursued the rehabilitation of migrant workers, setting up health camps and shelters for them, providing dry rations and cooked food, even a monthly allowance.

The blueprint for supply of piped water to 10 million households as well as the promise of electricity in every household have also cemented Naveen's image as a welfarist CM.

Dubbing this the Odisha model of inclusive development, Amar Patnaik claims the state has seen poverty alleviation of 31 per cent in the past 20 years. "It hasn't happened through direct money transfer but by making more disposable income available to all," says the BJD MP, in a veiled reference to the central government's emphasis on direct benefit transfers. "Provision for food security to 92 per cent of the population, health for 77 per cent and access to smart education naturally create opportunities for extra income."

Voting for Naveen Patnaik, therefore, seems to have become a habit for the people of Odisha. He too seems content serving the people of his state, eschewing a larger pan-India role, and not because he does not command huge respect on the national stage. ■